

Sex and Soul on the GHAT

Art and water mark the possibilities of nirvana and the sweep of the absurd in this novel stretching from Venice to Varanasi

By Sam Miller



**JEFF IN VENICE,
DEATH IN
VARANASI**
by GEOFF DYER
Random House India
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Geoff Dyer's playful, allusive fourth novel is really two novellas, vaguely linked, alliteratively and aquatically, in a way that seems designed to unsettle the reader. The first novella is set in Venice during the Biennale art exhibition, and the second along the ghats of Varanasi. Water and art play a major role in both of them—and so does an uncertainty about the relationship between the author and the main character. As the first part of the title suggests, the hero (Jeff) is almost the author (Geoff), but not quite. We get a lot of other puns that involve the author's real surname (Dyer) and Jeff's surname (Atman—whose Sanskrit meaning is never explained for Western readers), and there's a lot of dying and dyeing, and even kangaroos make an entirely unexpected appearance in both parts of the book.

The first part of Dyer's diptych is a comic, very deliberate retelling of yet another novella, Thomas Mann's 1912 homoerotic *Death in Venice*. In both, an unappealing middle-aged writer travels to Venice, struggles with the local transport system, dyes his hair—and becomes besotted at first sight. However, unlike the writer in *Death in Venice*, the determinedly-heterosexual Jeff does not fall for a 14-year-old boy, but for a beautiful young American woman, named Laura—an echo of Petrarch's unconsummated love for a woman of the same name. However, this Laura—and the plot is at its most improbable

here—falls for him, unlike Thomas Mann's Tadzio or Petrarch's innamorata. And so between gondola trips, cocaine-sniffing parties, bellini-drinking sessions and the odd art exhibition, they get to know each other rather well, as Jeff, in a series of long descriptive passages written in language entirely unsuitable for a family magazine, proceeds to explore all her orifices. They part amicably, having had the occasional discussion about Laura's previous visit to Varanasi, to where the action now moves. Laura is not mentioned again, and neither is Jeff—who is, however, remarkably similar to, but not quite the same as, the unnamed narrator of the Varanasi novella.

In Varanasi, our narrator is writing a travel article—and the text here reads just like, well, a rather predictable Western travel article about a Hindu holy town. The non-fictional Ganges View Hotel is given a rave review, and Dyer certainly deserves a discount on his next visit—but the Varanasi tourist authorities may not be so welcoming. There's a lot of filth and begging and death; there are dogs chewing on human corpses and even a man who uses a cart to carry his grotesquely-enlarged testicles around the holy city. It's hard not to feel a frisson of pleasure when a passing cow swings its shitty tail across the mouth of our culture-shocked narrator, who gradually becomes one of those all-too-recognisable, bombed-out, hallucinating Western travellers muttering about their own god, in this case a kangaroo deity called Ganoona.



Illustration by SAURABH SINGH